

flourished. After his opera *Idomeneo* was a success in Munich in 1781, he wrote the German-language Singspiel (opera with dialogue) *Die Entführung aus dem Serail* for performance at Vienna's Burgtheater, an institution sponsored by Maria Theresa's successor, Emperor Joseph II. Opening in 1782, *Die Entführung* proved a major triumph. It tells the story of the hero Belmonte's attempt to rescue his beloved Constanze from a harem. Mozart's other works in this fruitful period include some of his finest piano concertos, a notable series of six string quartets dedicated to Haydn, and two of his best-known symphonies, the "Haffner" (1782) and the "Linz" (1783).

After a lengthy search for the right follow-up to *Die Entführung*, Mozart found his ideal librettist in the Italian poet Lorenzo da Ponte (see [box](#)). The result was *Le nozze di Figaro* (The Marriage of Figaro). First performed in the Burgtheater in 1786, it raised opera to a new level with the realism of its characterization subtly expressed in music. A tale of class and sexual politics, *Le nozze* chimed with Mozart's rebellion against aristocratic arrogance. It was very well received, but failed to match the success of *Die Entführung* in Mozart's lifetime.

In 1787, Mozart made his first visit to Prague, a city that took him to its heart. His second collaboration with da Ponte, *Don Giovanni*, was written for performance at Prague's Estates Theatre, where it premiered in October. Performances in Vienna followed in 1788, although Emperor Joseph was again worried by the complexity of the music, which he declared "too difficult for the singers."